was critical for both combating the terrorists and guiding the guests on how to stay safe and escape.

They communicated with the hotel guests in their rooms, asking them to follow security instructions, not to leave their rooms, switch off their mobiles and turn off the room power. Even the next day when the commandos came and evacuated the operators, they remained in the vicinity, waiting to resume duties if required, says Shirin Batliwala, vice president of food and beverages at the time of the attack, who was entrusted with coordinating relief operations for those affected.

The Taj's general manager, Karambir Singh Kang, was at a conference when he heard about the terrorist attack. He left the venue immediately and took charge of the rescue operations. Kang remained in the hotel, which he had served for nineteen years, during the three-day-siege. Kang's wife, Neeti, and their two young children, Uday and Samar, aged twelve and five respectively, were staying in a suite on the sixth floor of the hotel. But he did not leave his station to spirit them to safety. 'His bravery is typical of almost all the hotel's associates on duty that night and of the others who came in when they heard what was happening,' said Bickson in an interview to *The New York Times*.

When Kang's father, who had served in the Indian Army, spoke to his son and commanded him: 'Stay afloat with your ship or go down with it', Kang replied: 'How can you think I can leave? If it goes down, I will be the last man there.' And true to his commitment, Kang led the rescue efforts, evacuating as many people as he could until noon the next day. Only then did he take out time to check on his family. Unfortunately, it was too late. They had died of asphyxiation in the fire that had broken out. But even this tragedy did not stop him from continuing with his duty.

Some three years after the horrific terror attacks that gripped the nation, Mumbai and the Taj, Ratan said, 'The Taj, despite its solidarity, its majestic being, could never be what it has turned out to be without that spirit, without the selfless spirit, embodied in the staff and the management. They stood by at great risk to themselves and in some cases at the cost of their lives to protect the people who were here. And that became the symbol of the strength of Mumbai, the strength of the city. They did get hurt, but they did not fall. I [pay] my tribute to the edifice and the people of the Taj who are the light and spirit of this great institution.'